

war period was instituted and Priority Certificates were issued to control rail traffic.

Operations of several branches and railway lines were temporarily dismantled to meet the demand for rails and rolling stock in the regions of Mesopotamia, Eastern Africa, and Palestine. India also supplied men and material for railways in African countries, such as Kenya and Uganda. Locally manufactured railway material sufficient to construct almost 2,800 km of railway track, 229 locomotives, and 5,989 vehicles were sent from India. To meet its wartime debts, the British Government levied a surcharge on railway goods traffic. Expansion came to a screeching halt as well. For instance, the South Indian Railway dropped its plans to construct a 19-km-long bridge between Dhanushkodi and Sri Lanka.

Several trains were discontinued and those that continued to run were severely overflowing with travellers. Passenger comfort, always a problem in third-class carriages worsened as did overcrowding since these were now deployed for troops. Brand-new carriages and locomotives were hard to come by and, as a result, the Railway Board asked Indian members of the Legislative Council to instruct their constituents to avoid unnecessary travel.

Raising questions

Growing discontent with the railways among the masses, set against this backdrop of the war, almost mirrored the general dissatisfaction with British rule. National leaders, such as GK Gokhale, managed to pull the railways solidly into the sphere of Indian politics, which is best illustrated by his speeches and interactions as a member of the Imperial Legislative Council. Gokhale said: " ... if the Japanese ... are managing their Railways, I do not see why we should not be able to do so."

The leaders collectively critiqued the benefits of having the railways in India, and focused on the importance of transferring its management to the State and the exclusion of Indians from senior management roles.

The general disrepair that the railways had fallen into during and after the war, and the resulting deteriorating passenger services only fanned public discontent and anger. This lent force to the demand for an